



Dr Deepu Benson speaking at Open Source India

systems become important. AAC refers to tools and methods that help people communicate when speech alone is not sufficient. These can range from simple communication boards to advanced electronic systems.

Some AAC solutions are very simple. Communication boards, picture cards and sign language systems are examples of low-tech approaches. There are also high-tech systems that use touchscreens, speech generation and

eye-tracking technologies.

What matters is not whether a solution is high-tech or low-tech but whether it helps a person to communicate.

Looking for a practical solution

While working with our community, we were exploring the possibility of developing an AAC solution ourselves. During this process, we came across CBoard, a free and open

source AAC platform.

What attracted us to CBoard was its simplicity. It works on desktop computers as well as mobile devices. It can be customised easily, works offline and does not require specialised hardware. Its offline capability is particularly valuable in rural and remote areas, where reliable internet connectivity may not always be available, allowing users to communicate without depending on continuous network access.

Most importantly, it is available as open source software. For communities and institutions with limited resources, cost is a major concern. Many proprietary AAC solutions are expensive.

Open source platforms offer an opportunity to build affordable solutions while allowing communities to contribute improvements and local adaptations.

Supporting Indian languages

While using CBoard, we encountered a challenge that I found surprising.

Despite Kerala's high literacy levels, Malayalam support was not available on the platform until recently. We approached the developers, and Malayalam was eventually added. The localisation effort was carried out by a team of student volunteers led by Febin K. Dominic, who worked



Localisation of food items: Pasta and porridge replaced by rice and sambar